

neighbours CHINA

THE OLYMPIC FLAME

Inside China, there is growing alarm over the negative publicity the torch relay is attracting and global reactions to the Tibet issue. The Olympics event was to be its showpiece to the world but other issues, including domestic realities, could spoil the party.

■ By Dilip Bobb in Beijing

China has a new Hero of the Revolution. Her name is Jin Jing and she is the 27-year-old, wheelchair-bound, disabled athlete who valiantly defended the Olympic torch from pro-Tibetan protesters in Paris. Throughout last fortnight, photographs of her holding the torch dominated the front pages of Chinese newspapers and her interviews were replayed endlessly on TV. Reading the reports and editorials and watching the TV coverage in China, it almost seems like Jin single-handedly defended the country against a marauding army. That is a reflection of the mood in China's official circles and an increasingly militant public.

If China has a new hero, it also has an old villain, the "splittist" Dalai Lama who is demonised everywhere like he were Genghis Khan reincarnated. The media in China is generally given a free hand except in times of national crisis, when self-censorship and xenophobia take over, like it has now, and it becomes a mirror to official policy. The attempts by pro-Tibet activists to disrupt the Olympic torch relay have embarrassed the Chinese leadership like no other event since the 1989

Tiananmen Square killings.

For them, the Beijing Olympics was to be their great coming-out party, a showpiece event to display to the world the New China with its gleaming malls, flyovers, designer stores, luxury cars, skyscrapers and shiny happy people. It was meant to be a symbol of China's resurgence as one of the world's great powers. It has cost over £20 billion (Rs 1,60,000 crore), the most expensive games ever, with more being spent on a new subway system, highways, a new airport and a sewage system. The Chinese capital is being re-made for the Olympics and cost is not an issue.

Now, the world is conspiring to spoil the party and the key issue is loss of face. For the Chinese, there is nothing more demeaning. The torch relay and the protests that are shadowing its route are one aspect of public indignity. Even more worrying is the growing global condemnation of the crackdown in Tibet, its human rights record and the fear that the Olympics may face a partial boycott by world leaders—a bigger loss of face considering the effort that has gone into its making.

UN Secretary-General Ban Ki-moon has already said he will not attend the Games' opening ceremony, Steven Spielberg has pulled out from

